For the Tainted Sorrow

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/33222637.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Inspired by Bungou Stray Dogs, Chuuya!Catra, Dazai!Adora, Inaccurate For the Tainted Sorrow, Mild Blood, Exes, Getting Back Together, Corrupted Catra (She-Ra), Confessions, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Angst, No Bungou Stray Dogs Knowledge Needed, No Longer Human (Bungou Stray Dogs) - Freeform, Mentions of Murder, Illustrated Fic, Blood, Minor Violence

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by JazzKat1213

Summary

"Her powers *are* under her fucking control; the Corruption won't pour forth without her giving into it… But she can't survive it without Adora to nullify. Weaver knows that. Has spat her glaring weakness in her face an uncountable amount of times. But it meant she could never get rid of her, could never rip her away from Adora lest she fall victim to herself. She couldn't stop them *being together* in all senses of the word, no matter how obvious she made her hatred of it."

Catradora as Soukoku/Double Black - Bungou Stray Dogs AU

Notes

For my friend who kept referring to Chuuya!Catra as Chuutra, and Dazai!Adora as Adorazi; you hurt me, I love you <3

Based on this scene:
"
Meanwhile, at the center of the light, Chuuya was closing in on Dazai's floating corpse. As blood trickled down his body, Chuuya clenched his fist and punched Dazau right across the cheek. The violent blow forced the knife out of Dazai's back, and Chuuya heard something burst - as if the pill in Dazai's mouth had been crushed from the impact.
The capsule with its venomous-red-and-pure-white colouring broke open in Dazai's mouth, releasing the medicinal solution inside. The viscous liquid slid down Dazai's throat until eventually, long, slender fingers touched Chuuya's ghastly, corrupted face. When they made contact, it instantly nullified his skill.
"…Did you use Corruption because you believed in

me? You're gonna make me cry…," came a calm voice. It was the voice of a man who was supposed to be dead.
Without even showing a hint of surprise, Chuuya responded, "Yeah, I trusted you were too damn crafty and far too stubborn to just die."
The corruption in Chuuya's body had already disappeared. Dazai had nullified it. He placed a hand on Chuuya's cheek where it had been punched and smirked slightly. "So this is how you wake Snow White? Kinda violent, don't you think?"
"Hey, you're the one who hid the antidote in yer mouth knowin' you were gonna get punched in the face," griped Chuuya, making his disgust no secret.
"

- Bungo Stray Dogs, *Dead Apple*

Adora's power is 'No Longer Human' - she can disable all other powers by touching. Hence she is Weaver's favourite out of fear more than anything else.
Catra's power is 'For the Tainted Sorrow' - she has a godlike entity inside her that is a weapon of mass destruction but will kill her without Adora to nullify. In this AU the god - the Corruption - makes a portal form that starts ripping reality apart by feeding off her emotions and life force. She also has gravity manipulation, though in this AU it only really works inside the Corruption's dimension.

Art by toffi (corviderii on tumblr):



See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

Adora's just floating there, immobile in the vortex of the portal she made.

Catra remembers setting it off, the Corruption that lives inside her burst out with her rage and her heartache. It's Shadow Weaver's fault - it's *always* her fault.
The bitch thinking she can take her powers to the good guys like they'll want her, accept her. But they did. The fucking good guys… she should've seen them taking pity on a desperate newly powerless woman, should've seen *Adora* doing that. She wouldn't turn her away.

And now she is safe and helping the enemy. She left just like everyone else, too obsessed with Adora's power, too cowardly to be around *her* when Adora wasn't there to keep the Corruption under control. When she no longer had the power to *'put her down'* like Weaver promised she would, should she ever lose her worth.

Her powers *are* under her fucking control; the Corruption won't pour forth without her giving into it… But she can't survive it without Adora to nullify. Weaver knows that. Has spat her glaring weakness in her face an uncountable amount of times. But it meant she could never get rid of her, could never rip her away from Adora lest she fall victim to herself. She couldn't stop them *being together* in all senses of the word, no matter how obvious she made her hatred of it.
Adora meant she could use her powers at all - meant the portal and the dark energy making it would meet an end. It kept Weaver safe as much as anyone else. They don't know if it *will* end naturally otherwise, or if it will just…consume.

As soon as Adora left the Horde she was useless. Shadow Weaver brought her into her office as soon as it was made clear Adora was never coming back to the mafia, told her she was a ticking

time bomb, that she'd be there to *personally* dowse her fuse. There's no one to stop her now that she's crippled the woman.

Everyone was terrified of her - *is* terrified of her. Before today she wasn't sure if they even should be. She can fight the war with everything she has *but* the Corruption. Her claws and teeth can only do so much; she is used to having more, *being* more. The Rebellion have powers, more than they do, and they can fucking use them. They *have* been using them and the Horde is losing because of it.

Time bomb was right because she gave in. She didn't think of it as suicide at the time but that's what it was; what it still is. Crossing into Rebellion territory and just walking up to their stupid little detective headquarters, calling out for Adora with the void distorting her voice. She knows Adora's told her new friends that her powers won't hurt them. She's condescending about it now in a way she never used to be.

"She can't hurt us, not without killing herself, and not while I'm here."
"Aw, that's not quite true is it? You've been by my side every time. If I couldn't hurt anyone, all those people wouldn't be dead."
"You wouldn't dare."
"You really wanna test that?"
She's put a lot of effort into proving Adora wrong to her friends. Adora is a liar. They should all know that.

It used to be from caring; the reminders of her power's limits. They were warnings drenched in worry. Adora wanted *her* safe, used hold her at night and kiss over her heart, tell her all those people were Horde enemies; they would've died sooner or later. Now Adora just wants to protect her new friends, assure them that her old *ally* can't really hurt them. And it is always *ally*, not friend, not lover. That's what they were even if they never said it out loud.

Adora used to know her better than anyone. She probably thinks she still does. But she's wrong because clearly Adora doesn't know

what a wreck she is. She's forgotten how much is an act. She thinks she's fine - or she just *doesn't care*, and that possibility hurts worse. Adora always did talk like she was going to just choose to give into the Corruption one day. She never would have done it if she'd *stayed*. So in some ways Adora was fucking right, because here she is. She said she wouldn't burn herself and the world out just to win a war, and she believed it. But she's always been a liar too.

Her fingertips start losing shape and form first, they always do, her matter dripping away as pale pink liquid to the ground, swallowing up the cobblestones.
And it spreads, as corruption does.

The void crawls up her arm like undead vines, up her neck and consumes her eye. Pale pink-white and nebulous black swirl in a galaxy at her feet, washing at its growing boundaries with each drip, drip, drip. Reality disappears with the Corruption taking over her eye; the portal's growing vortex begins swirling, howling in the distance. She is the eye of the storm, the center, the source. She is everything in here.
And she is nothing out there. Not without this.

The horizon isn't the city skyline anymore, the portal's light flares at an unknown boundary, a wall reaching skyward. She's always wondered what it looks like on the outside; whether they see anything like she does, or just the buildings being pulled apart by an invisible force. Whether they see pure, true black eating the city with her at the center little more than a monstrous figure. Maybe it just doesn't end. The world - the other world, the real one - could stop and she wouldn't know, wouldn't care.
She's drunk on power and freedom and pain and anger. She can roar with the void and find no consequence for it.

Up and down the streets, everyone caught in her power is floating like they're underwater. It's ethereal and it's awful. It's a false peace, forced sleep. It's the kids that manage to break through the veil of her rage even slightly; they don't deserve this. They don't deserve to die for the Corruption's hunger. But she's a killer,

the Horde wouldn’t allow her to be anything else. And nothing she's ever done has been enough to rid her of her own feelings. She won’t be able to live with this. And part of her knows it doesn't even matter anymore, she won’t live *through* this to begin with. She will be Corruption, the entity will take her over and there won't be anything left of her when it's done. It makes consequence seem fake.

And that’s not...that’s not an excuse. But it’s hard to reason with herself why, as far gone as she is. She feels like she’s on a cliff edge at the top of the world, everything else is just noise floating up to her.

She’s hurt and scared and angry and she wants it all to end and she wants to win and she wants Adora back. The Corruption makes emotion raw. It *feeds* on it. It’s drawing everything out and making it worse, and she can’t stop it. She was prepared to kill herself to do it and she still is. But the regret. The regret is growing like a tumour. She’s never felt it in this space; Adora’s always been there, waiting at a boundary, and all she had to do was walk over to her once she got caught in it. All she had to do was touch her, hold her, as the power rushed back inside the cage of her skin. The power’s never gotten this far. She always knew some would survive, and that those who didn't were unknown enemies. The world’s going to end and it’ll be all her fault.

“You’re not powerful enough to end the world. You’re too weak. You’ll be eaten up before then and the Horde will have one less volatile weapon to worry about.”
She wants to prove Shadow Weaver wrong. She wants to be strong, dangerous. She wants to be in control.
She doesn’t want the world to end.

The rubble is floating in the portal’s hurricane, walls and roofs, windows and doors all peeling away. She controls the gravity in here, she was pulling everything apart. She can slow it down with what little clarity she still has, but it can’t stop. Unstoppable force; cosmic, inhuman, uncaring. It’s beautiful in a way she’s never been able to describe.

The Corruption will destroy her last, it'll make her watch. She knows that somehow, the entity in her skin *makes* her know that. She didn't think this through. The animalistic simplicity of emotion, the bladed sharpness of thought, the blackness bubbling inside and out; it all condenses into one thing.
She made another mistake. Like always.

The Corruption will burn the thought out of her soon enough. It wants to live, grow, destroy. Her legs, most of her torso are void now, feeling lost to them. She'll forget why she was even fighting this in minutes. She'll want the destruction, she'll want to fall into it.
But she'll always want Adora with her when it happens.

She needs her, as tragic as it is and as horrible as relying on anyone makes her feel, she needs Adora to nullify the monster crawling out of her. She can feel every heartbeat in here, there's hundreds. She can feel energies, the powers of the Rebels, and even Shadow Weaver. It's hard to pick them apart but she'd know Adora's heartbeat anywhere, and that's all she needs. Her pulse holds the antidote and she can find her. She won't apologise, she never does. But she can save the world from herself.

The ground underneath her won't break since it needs her suffering, her emotion, to feed off. Maybe that's why this is so much more; why the portal's pink-red-white is flashing with lighting and storm clouds above her head. She's in more pain than she's ever been in. There's no sadistic glee in this, there's no fearlessness for it to writhe in.
It takes steps, just a few hard steps, the gravity pulling her down as the epicenter follows her. But she can feel her own stupidly mortal heart skip a beat at seeing Adora in her stupid coat and bandages in the agency's fracturing hallway. Adora was coming for her - to stop her, sure - but she is *there*. Looking as peaceful as she did on those few better nights in their old bed. She tears the door apart to see her properly.

The cosmic thing taking hold of her limbs doesn't feel love. But it *wants*. That's all it knows *how* to do. Want and feed and destroy.

And it drives her forward, encouraging selfishness, demanding more. The sight will hurt when Adora's power is activated, when she's mortal again. Now the Corruption is *happy* to see it, possessive over the sight. This is the closest she's been to having Adora since she left.

The Corruption is eating away at Adora too. It's never done that - it shouldn't *do* that, not to her. She doesn't know why it has. Whether it's because the Corruption's never gained this much power before, or because of her own feelings, it doesn't matter. If she were still truly herself she'd be horrified as the void winds up Adora's legs, pulsing red in time with her heartbeat. There's blood on Adora's lips, running down her chin and onto her white shirt before the droplets swirl in the air.

Catra just has to reach out and touch her and it's all over. The Corruption doesn't know that and she's starting to forget herself. She touches Adora and it's over; they live, she runs before the Rebels get her. She makes her way back to the Fright Zone and tries to figure out how to work her mistake into a fear tactic. She tries to convince everyone she's not weak. She tries to forget that she's sleeping in the bed she and Adora shared.

All the fear, all the aching, all the love isn't here. Everything that prevents her, makes her scramble away from admitting that she misses her, wants her back in her arms and under her lips, is gone. She is a vessel for wanting. And she wants Adora.

She presses her lips to Adora's at the same time her Corrupted fingers touch her cheek. The cool of Adora's power floods through her immediately like a breeze. There's blood in their teeth and the beast, though howling at being reined in, is satisfied as it retreats back into her skin. It's done. It's over. And she keeps kissing her like Adora's power will vanish if she breaks it. She is still cosmic, she is still wanting, but her love is flooding back. And it makes her stop. The storm around them has halted and it feels like the world she made is holding her breath with her. Adora opens her eyes before anything else, finding her gaze like that's all she was ever

meant to do. And she's beautiful in a tragic way; with the blood smeared on her lips.

"Hey Adora."
Adora gasps as the gravity sinks in and the Corruption retreats from her legs. And even looking like the monster she is, Adora clings to her in the portal space same as always. Adora puts a hand on the side of her face that hasn't been melting away. She still hasn't said anything and Catra's glad the Power hasn't receded enough to allow her fear to return.

But Adora's angry. She can tell that, she doesn't need her words. The hand on her face grips instead of rests and the arm around her neck pulls her closer.
"What the fuck did you do?"
"I woke you up didn't I?"
Apparently she's mortal enough again to resist burying under Adora's chin. It's not like she'll be able to find the comfort in her scent the way she craves, anyway, not when she's like this.

"*Why* did you set it off? Catra, why did you *do* that? You could've killed everyone!"
"I still might."
She won't. But she might want to.
Adora just looks confused…hurt. She can't understand it. She's always hurt people, this isn't any different. It's not any fucking different when she's hurting herself.

Adora's eyes flick down and she'd purr if she could. Their hair, both of their coats, are whipping with the gravity shifts. She wants Adora's ponytail down, she doesn't have the mind to stop herself. She smiles brokenly as the gold comes spilling. Adora presses her fingers to her own lips and they come away bloody. In her sick mind she hopes she has Adora's blood stained on her lips for the rest of her life, just to prove this happened.

"You kissed me?"
There's the pain again, sharp and cutting, as brutal as her claws. She can't tell that it's fear. It's just pain. She wants it to stop. She

fights baring her teeth.
Adora clutches onto her tighter, maybe she's afraid that they'll be dragged into closing portal beneath their feet. Adora's face is blurred pink, it takes Catra a second to realise that it's because she's crying. She's never cried in here before, her tears are the portal liquid and Adora's hand sizzles with it like acid. Adora doesn't move, doesn't even blink.

She can't deny what she did. She doesn't really want to. But this isn't some rough demanding thing where they're hidden away somewhere, there's no excuses when she is - was - just pure want. She can't spill all her usual explanations about how it is just because Adora is the only one who Catra can bear to have touch her, how she's the only one she trusts to not hurt her.

"You gotta kiss Snow White for her to wake up, right?"
"You -"

Her mortality comes rushing back as Adora kisses her. Or at least it feels like it. Her pulse is there, she can feel her body again just to leave it. Iron explodes on her tongue, and she's growling, her voice and the Corruption's mixing together. It's desperate and she needs it, craves it. She needs Adora to want her again, even if she never loved her and never will.
She can remember their last kiss with startling clarity; Adora sweeping her up in her arms and bleeding relief into her lips when she found her again. And then she told her she was leaving. And everything, much like now, came crumbling down.

"You said you'd never set it off if I wasn't there. You said you *weren't* going to kill yourself, Cat-"
"- You left. *She* left. I don't have anything without my power, and I don't have my power without you… I don't want to live without you. I - I just fucking *can't*, Adora."
"All you have to do is come with me. It's that simple. You know I can protect you from them, you know you can protect *me* if they're not using powers." Adora brushes more tears from her cheek, her hand is bleeding from it. "We can be a team again. We can be *us* again."

The boundary is closing in, only a couple of streets away. They're running out of time and her feelings are overwhelming now that they're back in her mind, in her chest. She can't breathe and she understands how she set it off in the first place. There's no big picture anymore, there is just Adora's worried, pleading eyes in front of her. She holds onto Adora's hips like she's done a million times - though never with her fingertips still void. The Corruption is winding back down her arms and Adora finally feels warm again as she kisses her a third time. She makes it gentle and slow, the way they never really did, never really could. And Adora melts after a moment's hesitation.

"That included?" she breathes afterwards.
Adora grips onto her coat lapels as she rests their foreheads together, "Yes, yes of course, anything you want. I just need you with me, not against me."
She growls again, "But what do you *want*?"
Adora has the audacity to be shocked, "What?"
"Do you want me again, Adora?"
"I - Yes. Yes, I've always wanted you… And more."
"…More?"
"It's more than just wanting. I - I love you. Fuck, why is it so scary to say that?"

She thinks she's falling. And then she is because the portal rushes back into her as it closes. They're both still holding onto each other, and Adora drops to her knees with her. The gravity shift is disorientating as always but it is fucking *nothing* compared to hearing Adora say *that*.
She's staring at Adora's collar, not seeing the ruined agency hallway around them.
"Please, just say something."
Air rushes into her lungs as the static in her ears cuts out. She looks up and Adora is just as wide-eyed, only a lot more scared. Catra's tears are finally water again, and they come running down her face as she smiles. For the first time in so fucking long, it's not pained or filled with malice.

Her purr is trying it’s damn best to break through. It can’t, not really. Not when she’s crying and smiling as well, not when Adora is beaming with hope as she crashes their lips back together.
“I love you, too.”

II

Chapter Summary

Months before the confession, Adora ended up chained to a wall.

Chapter Notes

The original dungeon scene on YouTube



Art by Corviderii on Tumblr

See the end of the chapter for more notes

~~ Months Before ~~

Catra knows she had a little too much fun watching some Horde lackeys bolt an unconscious Adora to the dungeon wall. It's payback, for all the times she's ended up alone in a room just like this because of her. Annoyingly she can't just *leave* her here though, she knows Adora can pick the locks, they both can. (Especially these kinds, the Horde never changes.) So she just leans against the wall, waiting for Adora like she always seems to fucking do.

It makes her angry in the interim between the lackeys leaving and Adora waking. It takes an infuriatingly long time and her feet go numb from standing. She watched as her Horde operatives descended on Adora, it was quick and Catra only hit her once, her being out this long is pathetic really. Some hideous part of her is happy to have this time to just look at her again, and she crushes it down as much as she can. There's still a blood trail, now dried, stuck to Adora's lip and chin from it that no one bothered to clean up. She's certainly not going to be any kind of gentle with her.

She crosses her arms and gets up close, kicking Adora's shin with her claws out. There's a small grunt, so at least she's close to coming around. She pokes at Adora's chest with a claw and there's the flutter of recognition in her waking features.
"You're boring when you're unconscious but at least you're quiet."
Adora mumbles, "Catra…"
She's not affected by Adora saying her name *like that*. She's not.
"And there goes that."

She steps back, watching as Adora groans and she rolls her neck out without even opening her eyes - always with the dramatics. Adora finally opens her eyes, one still a little bloodshot from a punch.
"Hey Adora." Adora doesn't answer beyond a twitch in her lip, but she does manage to raise her head to lean on the stone brick behind her. The glare Adora fixes on her is weak. "Well, this view's priceless, wouldn't you agree?"
Adora tugs on her wrists, and Catra smiles when they don't budge. "Bit much, isn't it?"
"Absolutely not. Only the best for a traitor." Adora frowns at

‘traitor’ as if she has any right to; it’s what she is. “I’d say it’s been a while, but it hasn’t. You’re a real pain in my ass, you know that?”

Adora just stares her down, and the challenge is familiar even if the poisonous air between them isn’t. There’s too many times where this has happened that ended with bruised lips. Maybe Adora knows that, maybe she’s fighting to remember how bad her situation is. Catra hopes she gets to watch that rebellious spark in her eyes die.
“How’s being powerless going for you?”
Going right for the kill, there’s really not much else Adora could say that would fan her anger as well as that does. She growls, loud enough for it to ricochet in the dungeon, and rushes up into Adora’s space. She fists Adora’s hair, and Adora’s clearly not happy about the pained sound she makes. It’s not one Adora’s ever made before when she’s pulled on her hair, but right now her anger means this is *better*.

“Disrespectful prisoners get scars, Adora.”
She had to learn that the hard way. Adora probably thinks the Corruption made a lot of her marks but she’s fucking wrong. It was all Shadow Weaver, usually in a cell far smaller than this. For promising to always have her back, Adora doesn’t know half the shit she’s been through because of her, for her.
“You would’ve learnt that if you were any decent sort of partner.”
“And what’s that supposed to mean?”
“Fuck you.”
She throws Adora’s head back into the wall as she lets go of her hair, half hoping she passes out again. She crowds Adora in with hands either side of her head, watching her wince at the pain but stay awake.

“You let yourself get captured. Why?”
Adora snorts quietly, face set stubbornly. It’s too familiar, Adora’s just treating this like a game, like nothing’s happened. She’s always been stupid though. Catra lets her claws dig into the wall by Adora’s face, hoping she takes it as the threat that it is.
“This isn’t what it used to be. You don’t get to be dismissive of me

anymore. No one does." Of all things, seeing pity on Adora's face is the one emotion that serves to make her hate her more. "You know what, let's see if I can guess."

She takes her claws out the wall, letting them snap all the way out and grinning at how completely they capture Adora's attention. She draws a single red line down Adora's jaw, listens to how her breath hitches. So predictable.
"This is an interrogation and a punishment at the heart of it, so try not to enjoy this, traitor."
"I won't."
Adora's pulse and scent always gives her away, just as it does now, the beat jumping under her claws and the smell by no means *just* fear. "You're a shit liar, always have been. But it's fine, you don't need to tell me, I already know why."
"Oh yeah?"
"Gave yourself up to save your new friends, didn't you?"
Adora's eyes flicker to the side and she rolls her shoulders as much as she can. "Did they get away?"
They did, helped by the fact that one of Adora's new friends can fucking teleport. The purple one has been really annoying.
Adora relaxes into the wall, looking far too proud of herself. "Then I say I won this round."

She taps her claws on a metal cuff. "Oh yeah, this looks like winning."
Adora leans forward as much as she can, smiling that cocky smile with a bloodied nose. "Then let's fight and decide it."
"No."
Adora pouts and in another time it might've worked. "Come on, don't you want to see if you can finally beat me?"
"Tempting. But you're mine now, Adora. I control you, you know I would never give that up."
"I *was* yours. I'm not the reason we're done."
Adora just keeps *lying*; she was never hers. Not in the same way Adora had her. And it's not *her fault*. She's not the one who left, she didn't *leave* Adora. She stayed exactly where all their promises were made.

“We’re not done. Done would mean I’d never have to see your face again.”

A cuff falls away from one of Adora’s wrists, quickly followed by the second. She’s not surprised, just annoyed really. There’s no point bolting her back in again when she’ll just get out. So she just steps back and glowers at where Adora’s rubbing her reddened skin.
“Learnt that from you,” Adora says as if there's still some affection left between them.
Catra doesn’t respond, quietly seething and trying not to slice her own hands open with her claws. Adora steps forward and it really is too comfortable and practised the way she dances to the side so Adora can’t get too close.
“Fight me, Cat - ”
She rushes in and swipes at Adora’s stomach, it tears clothes and the skin on the back of Adora’s hand because of course she caught it. “Still fighting dirty?”
“Always.”
Adora looks down at the gashes, speaking all too assuredly, “Good thing I know you.”
“You *think* you know me. But you left and expected me to run to your heel like a dog, so I’d beg to differ.”

She runs in again, kicking Adora’s legs out from under her and getting a punch to the stomach when she tries to pin her to the ground. She jumps back to her feet just as Adora rolls up to standing, telling her, “I know how you fight. That’s enough when we’re on opposite sides.”
Catra’s the one with her back to the wall, she pretends she doesn’t know that and holds her arms out, “Come on then. Do your worst.”
Adora can clearly tell that it’s a trap, but she comes in any way because she’s an idiot and she never did know when to hold her punches. The opportunity to run is right fucking there, even though Catra is sure she would catch her, Adora doesn’t even think to take it.

The hit to her face is worth it to be able to grapple Adora's other arm and force it up into the space between her shoulder blades. She spins Adora's back into the wall and grabs her throat with her claws, lets her bleed a little. It's barely a few droplets but the iron fills her nose anyway.
"You're always underestimating me, you know that? I wasn't *allowed* to hurt you before. If I ever left marks, I'd end up in a place like this."
Adora's scoff comes out hoarse. "Don't bullshit me, you left marks all the time. I certainly had them the last time you pinned me like this."
"Yeah, and guess what? I got starved out in a cell for daring to put a visible mark on Shadow Weaver's golden girl."
She can at least find some satisfaction in Adora's sudden guilt, in the way she sinks into the wall. "You weren't avoiding me?"
"*No*, you - you are so *stupid*."

She drops her hands down. She doesn't want to fight when Adora can just *say things* at any moment. She wants to go shoot something, escape all the memories and feel accomplished at *something*. Adora's too good at dragging forth the shadows in her mind - ones that Adora was too self-involved to even know about even though they were *her* fault. Or even better, she wants to let the Corruption loose. She has her failsafe here, she could. But she'll just get in trouble for it, and the momentary power rush isn't worth that. And besides, she's meant to get answers and make sure Adora doesn't escape. So, she might as well *get answers*.

"You were the youngest executive in Horde history. Why would you give that up, everything you've ever worked for?"
"Why did you never tell me you wanted it so badly?"
She hisses but it's weak. She never told her because there was never going to be any chance that Shadow Weaver would let it happen. And she didn't, it was Hordak who told her to choose Catra as the replacement. And Weaver can't say no to the boss, no matter how much she detests it.

“Catra, there’s an executive meeting in two days to decide the fate of the Horde. Hordak will be there. Do you know where that is?”
For a second she’s just shocked that Adora’s *asking* that like she’ll tell her anything. But she doesn’t know about this meeting, and it seems like Adora knew that, or at least suspected. So Weaver didn’t tell her. Of - of *course* she didn’t. For all the times the bitch has threatened to kill her, she’s never gone through with it. Now it seems like she’s trying to get Hordak pissed enough to do it for her. Joke’s on her, Hordak probably won’t care about her presence enough to notice whether she’s there or not.

“Catra, the Horde don’t care. About anybody. They want money, they want territory and they hurt everyone doing it.”
Yeah well, she knows all that. She is the one that’s *been* hurt. Adora just skated by on Weaver’s favour, apparently not questioning the Horde’s good mission even when she walked past people ruined by their operation every day.
“And? I want money, I want power. I have it, why should I care about anyone else when no one’s ever cared for me?”
Adora turns pleading, Catra’s learnt not to listen to it. “I care.”
Liar. “You don’t *count* anymore.”

Adora looks wounded before she schools it, and Catra *doesn’t care*, she really doesn’t.
“Fine. But you’re a good person Catra, underneath it all. That’s why.”
She turns away, she doesn’t want to hear it, she doesn’t want to look at Adora when she lies. “Good doesn’t matter. Good doesn’t get you anywhere but in pain or dead. Or captured in your case.”

“Hey, you’re the one letting me go.”
She knows her ear flicks. “Who said anything about that?”
Adora responds, in that tone that she *could* use because she was never the one to get the punishments, “Don’t know if you realised this, but I’m free.”
“And yet you’re still here annoying me,” she snaps, and all Adora does is huff. “You can’t get past me, Adora. You know that.”
She doesn’t actually. She doesn’t know what she can do to her. But she can bluff.

“I can wait you out.”
“As if.”
“How long’s it been since you last slept?”

She growls, full well knowing about the black marks under her eyes. She turns just her head back at the sound of footsteps, ready to maim Adora if needs be. Adora’s too close, stupidly close. And then her hand comes up, Catra means to bite at it, make her bleed more for even daring to touch her. But Adora’s fingertips just brush over her cheek, she still growls, but she doesn’t do anything else either.
“I’m fine.”
“Yeah, you sure look it.”
She does bite then, but Adora dodges, laughing quietly. She can still recognise that it’s a nice sound even if she hates her. Hates that her weakness is so obvious whenever Adora gets involved.

“Do you remember that mission out of town, away from Shadow Weaver? How happy we were?”
Adora says it quietly, carefully, as if that makes it alright. Catra snarls and pushes her away - she doesn’t want to think about the bad memories, let alone the good ones. Adora just pulls her back in with hands on her hips, ignoring the claws she digs into her arms.
“I remember that suit you wore to our first formal negotiation. Do you remember mine?”
It’s so fucking *infuriating* how even just the briefest thought to that day still makes her blood pump faster. “Of course I do.”
Something gives her away, given how sharp Adora’s eyes get.
“You remember afterwards.”
It’s not even a question. She’s not sure she could forget their first time together, hidden away in a casino bathroom, dressed in clothes more expensive that they could have ever dreamed of affording. It makes her tail lash. She hates this, she hates everything about this. Adora needs to *leave* if she’s not going to stay.

Adora knocks their foreheads together and she needs her to *stop*.
“You’re going to let me go.”

"*No*, no I -"
"- Just this once."
It's not fair. Nothing's ever - it's never been fucking fair. She doesn't even know why she even hopes things change anymore. Adora's got the power - over everyone really. Over her more than anyone. Adora controls the Corruption whether she knows that or not, she controls the way Catra's heart struggles and her mind yells.

It just snaps - everything all at once. She screams and hears the crack of stone come crashing down on the ground from her claws, feels the dust plume and cling to her face. Adora jumps back, braced for her claws that should be tearing into her. But she didn't. Because she's weak for her, and the only thing she did was streak Adora's face with powder and send a few blonde hairs floating to the floor.
"I hate you." Her hand slips off the stone, and she just stands there staring at the slash marks with Adora breathing in her hair. And she sighs, "I'll give you a thirty second head start."

Chapter End Notes

Adora's just got a lil bit of blood on her at all times in this fic, as is my right.
This is a Christmas present, funnily enough. They gift me fanart, I rewrite them the Soukoku dungeon scene.
The drama of friends to lovers to enemies to lovers >>>>>

End Notes

Corviderii is also drawing more spop characters as bsd characters! Now Out

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!